



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Historical drama

DIRECTOR

Sergei Eisenstein

WRITER

Nina Agadzhanova

STARS

**Aleksandr Antonov,
Vladimir Barsky,
Grigori Aleksandrov**

BEFORE

1925 Eisenstein's first full-length feature, *Strike*, tells the story of a 1903 walkout in a Russian factory and the repression of the workers.

AFTER

1928 Eisenstein's *October* (*Ten Days That Shook the World*) uses a documentary style to tell the story of the 1917 October Revolution.

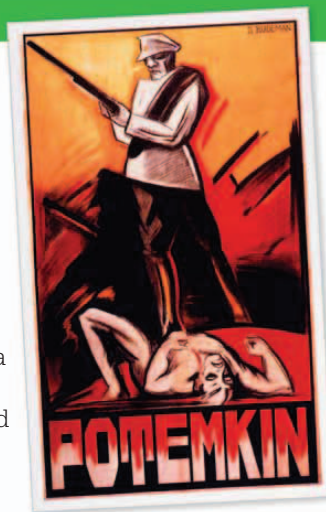
1938 In a more restrictive political climate, Eisenstein retreats to distant history with *Alexander Nevsky*.

WHAT ARE WE WAITING FOR?

BATTLESHIP POTEMKIN / 1925

Sergei Eisenstein's *Battleship Potemkin* was commissioned by the Soviet authorities to commemorate the 20th anniversary of the 1905 Revolution, when Russian sailors mutinied against their naval commanders and protested in the port of Odessa (now in Ukraine). The result was a movie that revolutionized cinema. Ninety years later, it is rare that an action movie does not owe it something.

The opening scenes are historically accurate. The cooks did take issue with the maggot-ridden



This was one of the first movie posters by Dutch designer Dolly Rudeman. It depicts a Cossack soldier with one of his victims at his feet. Its bold futurist style is typical of 1920s posters in Europe.

meat, only to be told that it was fit for consumption. The crew's spokesman, Quartermaster Grigory Vakulinchuk (Aleksandr Antonov), did call for a boycott and was shot. The crew did turn on their superior officers before hoisting a red flag and sailing to Odessa, where there had been ongoing civilian unrest. And Vakulinchuk's body was put on display, with a note: "This is the body of Vakulinchuk, killed by the commander for telling the truth."

When the sailors reach Odessa, however, Eisenstein's movie veers into propaganda. While it is true that Tsar Nicholas II took action against the striking citizens of Odessa, this did not happen at the

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View it in the same way that a group of artists might view and study a Rubens or a Raphael.

David O. Selznik

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